## FEATURES OF THE THIRD WORLD

***Colonial Past:*** The Third World countries share a common history of being subjugated under European colonialism. The European powers imposed their domination on the peoples of Africa, Asia and Latin America as they carved out colonies for themselves. They virtually converted these colonies into 'raw material appendage' in order to feed their economies. The prosperity of the European countries was at the cost of the underdevelopment and exploitation of these colonies. Frustrations and discontent against the colonial rule gave rise to nationalist struggles in all these colonies, which ultimately forced the European colonial powers to grant them independence. This colonial legacy prompted the Third World countries to zealously guard their independence and gear up their resources and energy towards development.

***Poverty and Underdevelopment:*** Poverty and underdevelopment linger in the South. The onus is not only on the North but also on the internal structure of the South. If the South's uncommitted leadership, misallocation of its limited resources, huge population growth and sluggish economic growth contribute to poverty, the North's tactics of trade and aid, WTO and IMF's structural adjustment programmes, world price fluctuations, financial instability in the global stock markets, global financial crisis (2008), protectionist regime of the North, and the role of MNCs have also increased the underdevelopment of the Third World countries. The World Bank has produced a list of 140 'failed states' that are either developing countries or former socialist countries, but with huge natural resources. This has again given the North another opportunity to intervene in these developing countries, and justify their activities as efforts to save the failed states and spread democracy so that they do not become the breeding grounds of international terrorists.

***Debt Crisis:*** In the 1980s there was a huge Third World debt crisis from which the developing countries found it difficult to re-emerge. The developing countries were encouraged to borrow more until the trap finally closed on them. 1979 was the turning point, as we will